Usability & UX Dimensions

Usability and User Experience can be used to analyze and characterize the interaction between a user and a system or a product. They can help us understand the degree to which the system is usable to interact with, and what kind of experiences it can prompt through interactions. When using this tool, be mindful of the following:

- Both usability and user experience are not properties of the system or the product itself, but of the interaction between a user and the system.
- These dimensions are qualitative in nature, and require you to analyze and describe elements of the design of the user interface and how a person interacts with it.

Usability Dimensions[1]		
Dimension	**Description**	**How to characterize**
Visibility	External signals of what can be done, how to do it, what is going on, and what was done.	Describe the design features (visual, audio, tactile, etc.) that allow the user (or prevent them) to know what to do and how, and what is going on. Consider the tradeoff between visibility and complexity/clutter.
Natural mapping	Spatial and conventional relationships between intentions, actions, controls, and outcomes.	Describe the relationships between users' intentions, the actions available to them through design features, and the responses to the user's actions. Consider the degree to which these relationships follow physical, cultural, and logical conventions.
Constraints	Limiting the number of alternative actions to the right ones that the user expects.	Describe the design features that limit the number of alternative actions for the user (or not), and how they allow the user (or prevent them) to complete the right action that they intend to.
Error recovery	Users can explore the system and reverse unwanted actions.	Describe how the system is designed for the user to commit errors (or not), the design features that allow the user to discover and explore the system without making irreversible mistakes, and the ability to recover from errors and undo actions.
Standardization	Internal consistency within the system, external consistency with other systems.	Describe the design features that are consistent (or inconsistent) with design standards in other systems, and the consistency within the system across screens and features.

[1] Based on Don Norman's The Design of Everyday Things, 1988.

User Experience Dimensions[2]		
Dimension	**Description**	**How to characterize**
Sensual	The sensory engagement of the user with the system	Describe how the user interacts with the user interface on a sensory level: sight, touch, sound, etc., and what design elements in the user interface trigger the user's sensory engagement.
Emotional	Emergent feelings being fostered through the interaction between the user and the system	Describe how design elements in the user interface trigger user's feelings, and how these feelings change dynamically throughout the flow of the interaction.
Social	Construction of shared meaning through interaction in a social context	Describe the social context in which the user interacts with the system, and how interacting with the system influences the user's social interactions and connections.
Contextual	The unique context of interaction in time, place, and situation	Describe the specific situation(s) in which the interaction happens: who, where, when, with whom, with what device, etc. and how this situation affects the interaction. Describe also how the context changes over time and how the interaction might affect the context.

[2] Based on McCarthy & Wright's Technology as Experience, 2004.